# REBUILDING SHIMLA

THE DELUGE IN JULY-AUGUST DEVASTATED THE HIMACHAL PRADESH CAPITAL. IT'S **A CRISIS FOR CM SUKHVINDER SUKHU, BUT ALSO AN OPPORTUNITY** TO REVERSE THE ILL EFFECTS UNBRIDLED CONSTRUCTION HAS WROUGHT ON THE HILL TOWN

By Anilesh S. Mahajan



**MUD SLIDE** A destroyed house in Krishna Nagar area in Shimla, Aug. 19

**For decades, the beginning of autumn** meant travelling to the hills, Shimla and its neighbouring tourist spots being a favourite for many families in north India. The cool air, clear skies and the tree cover flush after the rains made every trip a picture-postcard experience. The recently commissioned Kalka-Shimla highway only added to the allure. But not this year. The ferocious rains, initially in the first week of July, then in mid-August and in the last week of the month led to one of the worst calamities in the hill state's history. The debris from the landslides scattered across the hillsides on the new highway and the big machinery parked there to clear it are ample evidence of the devastation unleashed. Across the state, there are over 1,500 spots where the roads have caved in; around 200 bridges have also been washed away. This is in addition to the human cost: over 300 deaths have been reported officially while 38 people are still listed as missing.

In capital Shimla, an uneasy calm persists. The city and its neighbouring areas saw more than 2,200 homes being severely damaged and another 10,000 houses left in need of major repairs. Some 300 shops have also been ren-